

5, It Is Easy for People to Be Influenced by Various Concepts Due to Their Environments

Whether it is the Chinese people's ignorance of Western society or the citizens of Western developed countries' ignorance of Chinese society, both vividly demonstrate the formidable power of **concepts** (观念)—a point that I find utterly astonishing.

In fact, I can distinctly feel that the barrier standing between the Chinese and Westerners is by no means merely a lack of factual understanding. Rather, it is the reality that even after acquiring sufficient evidence, **people find it impossible to imagine or concede the very possibility that "such a society" could actually exist.** (*I will likely elaborate on this point later*).

Previously, when I was researching why the excessively powerful bureaucratic system of the Western Han Dynasty could be established so rapidly within a short period, I profoundly experienced, for the first time, the massive influence that concepts exert on people's judgments.

Because if we stand in the present day—taking an objective perspective 2000 years later, rather than adopting the perspective and limited information available at the time—it is a fact that the Xiongnu (匈奴) were powerful, and it is a fact that they posed a threat to the Han Dynasty. **But they were absolutely not as powerful as the Han Dynasty perceived them to be!**

The perceived invincibility of the Xiongnu within the minds of the Han people was deeply rooted in the people's ignorance of the world at that time, their lack of understanding of the enemy, their dread of being encircled, and their subjective feelings regarding the balance of power and the trajectory of the threat.

Speaking with the benefit of hindsight (以马后炮的角度来说), by 120 BCE, the Han Empire had practically already expelled the Xiongnu from the mixed agricultural-pastoral zones and opened the route to the Xinjiang region. Under such circumstances, it was highly unlikely for the Xiongnu to evolve further into a massive empire with a mixed mode of production; the probability of their continued political development had become exceedingly slim.

If the Han armies had simply ceased their deep, relentless pursuits from that point onward, maintaining a military standoff along the Han Great Wall supplemented by political maneuvering (政治调略), it would likely have only been a matter of time before the Xiongnu ultimately fractured. After all, although the Xiongnu possessed certain extraordinary qualities, they could not possibly transcend the social realities dictated by their nomadic **mode of production**. Therefore, there was an overwhelmingly high probability that the Xiongnu would no longer possess the power to subvert Chinese civilization (*at least until **feudalization** began*).

If we envision this historical possibility, we realize that the Han armies could have avoided several decisive clashes of their main forces, especially disastrously failed campaigns.

Furthermore, noticing that measures massively expanding government power—such as the state monopoly on salt and iron (盐铁官营)—only appeared *after* the decisive battle in Mobei (漠北决战 / the Gobi Desert), there is every reason to believe that **the Han bureaucratic system under that alternative choice would never have become as powerful, resilient, and capable of self-repair as it did in our timeline** (本位面).

(*I state this based on some far more granular historical facts. For instance, Gongsun Hong [公孙弘], a supremely important political figure during Emperor Wu's reign, passed away in 121 BCE.*

Coming from a humble background, Gongsun Hong was only promoted due to the emperor's appreciation after he was over fifty—which perfectly aligns with the general laws of the **classical bureaucratic period**. He was the first Chancellor [丞相] to be made a Marquis upon appointment, and according to historical records, the last Chancellor during Emperor Wu's reign to be deeply involved in political decision-making. Therefore, Gongsun Hong's death carries an indicative significance: it fundamentally signifies the completion of the separation between the Inner Court [内朝] and the Outer Court [外朝] during Emperor Wu's era. **The Chinese bureaucratic system officially detached itself from the classical bureaucratic structure—this was one of the most critical events in the developmental history of the Chinese bureaucratic system.** However, because time cannot flow backward, I usually do not meticulously explain the reasons behind my hypothetical speculations. After all, these hypothetical scenarios can never actually occur anyway.)

When feudalization genuinely occurred, China might not have inevitably walked down a dead end exactly as it did in our timeline.

Even from the emperor's personal perspective, it would have been beneficial: if the empire's "gear shift" (换挡) had occurred early, at least the probability of the tragedy of father and son turning against each other in his later years would have been significantly reduced.

However, we today know vastly more than the people of that era could have known. The Han people simply had never seen such a colossal nomadic empire, let alone possessed any understanding of world history.

The decisions made during the latter half of Emperor Wu's reign reflected the overarching concept forged by the Han people over nearly a century of coexistence with the Xiongnu: **when there is a chance to annihilate this formidable enemy, one must absolutely never show mercy!**

Because the Xiongnu had previously inflicted far too much humiliation upon the entire nation, forging an overwhelmingly intense psychological pressure. And because the entire nation had already sacrificed far too much to defeat the enemy, no one was willing to gamble on whether adopting a relatively conservative strategy now might allow the enemy to rise from the ashes.

We can even clearly see that, many years after Liu Che's (Emperor Wu's) death, military operations involving multiple Han armies marching simultaneously across the Mongolian Gobi to seek decisive strategic battles continued to exist. And the ideology regarding the Xiongnu as the ultimate enemy—"Those who offend our Han nation shall be executed, no matter how far away they are!" (虽远必诛)—persisted straight through to the late Western Han period.

This consciousness of constantly seeking decisive battles in hopes of utterly erasing the Xiongnu as a political entity clearly possessed a massive foundation within Western Han society. **This was precisely the concept formed through long-term interaction between the Han and the Xiongnu.**

Therefore, it is absolutely not absurd to conclude that this "concept"—which appears inaccurate to later generations—catalyzed the formation of an overly bureaucratic and highly centralized empire, **thereby permanently separating the historical trajectory of East Asia from other regions of the world.**

Because even today, we can effortlessly point out just how profoundly concepts influence people's cognition.

For instance, during the nearly half-century of the Cold War, did the Soviet Union—or the Soviet-led Eastern Bloc—possess the actual strength to rival the United States at any given moment?

The answer today is obviously: **Absolutely not. Not even for a single day.**

The Soviet regime was essentially a recently formed **restoration-bureaucratic regime** (*referring to its formation during the transition between the feudal and capitalist societies*). Although it could temporarily drive massive human and financial resources into a specific sector through coercive power—managing to produce some superficially glamorous achievements despite abysmal efficiency and astronomical attrition—such a society and such a political system inherently possessed zero possibility of securing victory in a prolonged competition with the United States.

Its **social efficiency** was far too low, and the forward direction of human society is not something a few high-level technocrats (技术官僚) can accurately foresee. Even in terms of technological innovation, the Soviet Union was forced into a position of trailing behind the West, only to be left further and further behind.

As for the threat of nuclear war, it is even more laughable. How could these extravagantly decadent privileged cliques (穷奢极欲的特权集团) possibly have the courage to risk seeing their luxurious lives instantly annihilated by actually initiating a nuclear war? Today, a year and a half into Putin's invasion of Ukraine, Russia has made nuclear threats more than once—but who still believes them?

We today can certainly say without blushing that believing the Russians were capable of rivaling the West back then was an absolute joke. However, when people of that era saw the Russian satellite go up into space first, or saw the massive military exercises conducted by the Soviet Union and its satellite states (仆从国), they did not think so.

NATO's heavy emphasis on the Soviet Union was not fake; the nuclear war prevention drills conducted by many Western European nations were not fake either. When people are situated right in the midst of the historical process, it is inherently difficult to judge where the world is heading. If one lacks a holistic grasp of the historical processes humanity has experienced thus far, attempting to make an accurate judgment is truly a fool's dream.

Therefore, whether it was the peoples of various Western European nations or the governments of the Western bloc led by the United States, **what they were attempting to combat was a Soviet Union constructed of "concepts"** (观念中的苏联). As for the true, self-unsustainable Soviet Union, it likely would not have survived a few extra years even if the US and other nations hadn't expended so much grueling effort.

Perhaps the most enduring and famous example of concepts influencing people is the **cavalry**.

Not long after the cavalry emerged on the historical stage as an independent military branch, the ancient Greek military commander Xenophon (色诺芬) explicitly pointed out that cavalry was not something to be feared.

When facing a cavalry charge, soldiers naturally fear being trampled by warhorses. But a cavalryman is not operating an emotionless machine; the horse he rides is fundamentally terrified of crashing into infantrymen! For a horse, suffering even a permanent leg injury—let alone a fatal wound—is virtually indistinguishable from a death sentence. Therefore, when cavalry recklessly charges toward the enemy, the horse itself will instinctively attempt to evade.

Xenophon astutely pointed out that not only should infantry not fear cavalry, but cavalry should actually be more terrified of infantry. Because the infantryman stands upon the solid earth, whereas the cavalryman must fear falling off his horse! (*Of course, we must comprehensively note that during Xenophon's era, certain horse tacks crucial for cavalry warfare had indeed not yet appeared*).

European military strategists and military manuals from the 16th to the 19th centuries repeatedly mentioned this exact point. One could say that at the very dawn of the cavalry's appearance, Xenophon had already seen right through this military branch: to counter a cavalry charge, all one needs is a well-trained infantry force whose formation will not waver in the face of enemy intimidation. The anti-Jin armed forces that achieved illustrious military exploits during the transition between the Northern and Southern Song Dynasties in our country are a perfect example.

Yet, despite this military branch being thoroughly analyzed the moment it appeared, one can find that in countless battles over two millennia, cavalry succeeded in shaking enemy formations! Many times, this was not even achieved through the highly efficient method of mounted archery (弓马骑射), but merely through intimidation charges (威吓式的冲锋), which alone were sufficient to throw poorly trained enemies into sheer panic and disarray.

This is an incredibly fascinating phenomenon.

When Xenophon commanded his Greek mercenaries fighting across various regions, Greece was still in the glorious era of numerous city-states. An army of heavy infantry composed of *city-state citizens* naturally and effectively restrained cavalry.

However, during the early-to-mid stages of **feudalization**, in regions that had not undergone feudalization, or in regions like China where **feudalization** had been abruptly interrupted, obtaining an army with formidable military discipline was no easy task. Wars were frequently fought between forcibly conscripted rabbles (被强行征发的乌合之众).

Against these massive but utterly low-quality armies, the cavalry of the **military aristocracy** could naturally secure victories like a hot knife slicing through butter. These battle outcomes, in turn, exacerbated people's terror of cavalry.

In fact, although I am not entirely familiar with how the European commoners view this now-obsolete military branch, I can say with absolute certainty that **the cavalry in history as perceived by the Chinese must be infinitely stronger than as perceived by the Europeans!**

This is because there are simply far too many examples of China's bureaucratic empires being crushed in absurdly pathetic ways by barbarians who had undergone a certain degree of **feudalization**.

In the subconscious minds of many people in our country, the moment elite cavalry charges, the victory is already sealed. They cannot even comprehend why mounted archery is actually the most efficient combat method for cavalry. (*Theoretically, for cavalry to charge directly into formed infantry carries an exorbitant cost and enormous risk. But because the armies of the Chinese Empire were always massively bloated yet completely incompetent [大而无当], if the enemy adopted this counter-intuitive tactic, it often yielded spectacular results!*) Consequently, military forums in our country are constantly obsessed with heavy cavalry.

In this way, the physiological terror brought about by a cavalry charge magnified through the accumulation of historical facts into a concept that *deified* the cavalry—and in China, this concept became exceptionally entrenched.

Therefore, it is truly not a rare occurrence for people, trapped by instinctual perceptions or the limitations of the facts they recognize, to generate erroneous concepts, and subsequently be shackled by these false concepts into making disastrous decisions.

Frequently reflecting on one's own standpoint and earnestly considering whether there is missing information is truly an absolute necessity.

5, 人们很容易因为自己所处的环境被各种观念所影响

无论是中国人对于西方社会的无知还是西方发达国家的公民对于中国社会的无知都展现了观念的强大力量,这一点是令我感到十分惊奇的。事实上,我能明显地感觉到阻挡在中国人和西方人之间的屏障绝不仅仅是对事实了解的缺乏,而是在即使了解了足够多的证据之后,也无法去想象或者承认确实存在“那样一种社会”的可能(这一点在之后可能还会再说)。在我之前研究西汉过强的官僚制度为什么会在短期内迅速建立起来的时候,就第一次深刻地感受到了观念对于人们判断所拥有的强大影响。因为站在现在,2000年后一个客观的角度来看,而不是在以当年掌握的信息和视角来看,匈奴人强大是事实,能对汉朝造成威胁也是事实,但是绝对不会强大到汉朝方面认为的那种程度。匈奴在汉人的观念上的强大,是深刻地建立在当时人们对于世界的无知,对于敌人的缺乏了解,对于被包围的担忧,对于力量对比和威胁程度趋势的感受上。以马后炮的角度来说,到公元前120年为止,汉帝国实际上已经将匈奴从农牧混合地区驱逐出去,并且打通了向新疆地区的路线。在这种形势下,匈奴不太可能再向一个拥有混合生产方式的大帝国演化,政治上继续发展的概率已经很小。汉军即使从此停止深入穷追,只是在汉长城一线与匈奴进行军事对峙,以政治调略为辅助,恐怕匈奴最后陷入分裂也是稍晚的事。毕竟匈奴人虽然具有一些非凡的品质,但是他总不至于超脱基于游牧这种生产方式的社会现实,因此这样有极大概率匈奴仍将不再拥有颠覆中国文明的力量(直到封建化开始为止)。

如果我们设想这样的历史可能性就会发现,汉军可以避免数次主力决战特别是失败的会战。而注意到诸如盐铁官营这样极大扩张政府权力的措施出现在漠北决战之后,就完全有理由相信该选择下的汉代官僚制度不会有本位面一样强大、坚韧且拥有自我修复能力。(我这么说确实是基于一些更为细致的历史史实,例如武帝时期极为重要的政治人物公孙弘就去世于公元前121年。公孙弘本人出身寒微,年过半百才因为皇帝的赏识一路提升,这是符合古典官僚时期一般规律的。他首以丞相封侯,并且是历史记载中汉武帝时期最后一个深度参与到政治决策中的丞相。因此公孙弘的去世具有一种指示性的意义,它基本意味着汉武帝时期内朝和外朝分离的完成,脱离了古典官僚体制的中国官僚制度正式形成,是中国官僚制度发展史上最重要的事件之一。但是因为时间不能倒流,所以我往往不会细致地解释我进行某种假定推测的原因,毕竟无论如何这些假设都不可能再发生了。)当封建化真正发生的时候,中国就不一定会像本位面一样走到一条绝路上去。甚至即使站在皇帝本人的角度也有好处,如果帝国的“换档”早早发生,至少晚年父子反目的悲剧发生的概率会小很多。可是我们今天所知道太多事情恰恰是当年的人不知道的,汉朝人就是没有见过这么庞大的游牧帝国,对于世界历史更是一点认识都没有,汉武帝统治后期的决策反映了汉人近一个世纪以来在与匈奴共存中产生的观念,那就是在有机会消灭这个强敌的时候就绝对不能心慈手软。因为匈奴曾经给整个国家带来了太大的屈辱,在心理上形成了过强的压力,而整个国家为了击败敌人已经付出了太多,所以没有人能赌现在采取相对保守的策略会不会使敌人死灰复燃。我们甚至可以明确地看到,即使是在刘彻本人去世之后很多年里,汉军几路大军并进越过蒙古戈壁寻求战略决战的军事行动照样存在,而对于作为敌人的匈奴“虽远必诛”的意识一直延续到西汉后期。像这样不断寻求决战以期彻底将匈奴作为一个政治实体抹去的意识显然在西汉社会具有十分广泛的基础,这就是基于汉匈之间长期交往所形成的观念。人们完全没有理由认为这种在后人看来并不准确的“观念”促成了一个过于官僚和集权的帝国形成,以至于很大程度使东亚的历史进程从此与其他地区永久的分开是荒谬的。

因为我们在今天仍然能够轻而易举地指出观念对于人们认识的影响是多么深远,就比如说,在冷战的将近半个世纪间,苏联或者说以苏联为首的苏东集团难道有任何一个时期具有与美国抗衡的实力吗?

现在的回答当然是，根本不存在，即使一天也不存在，苏联政权本质上是一个晚近形成的（这是指它在封建社会与资本主义社会之间过渡时）复辟官僚政权，他虽然可能在短期内通过强权驱使大量人力和财力投入某个方面，即使以极低的效率和极高的损耗也能办出一些表面光鲜的事业。但是这种社会也好，这种政治体制也罢，在与美国的长期竞争中就不存在任何取胜的可能，它的社会效率太低，人类社会前进的方向不是几个高级的技术官僚就能够看清的。即使从技术革新的层面来看，苏联也几乎不得不在西方身后跟随，就这样被甩得越来越远。至于战争的威胁更是可笑，这些穷奢极欲的特权集团怎么可能有勇气冒着自己的幸福生活被毁于一旦的风险去进行核战争？今天普京进攻乌克兰已经一年半，俄国进行的核威胁也不止一次，可是谁还会信呢？现在的我们当然可以面无愧色地说，认为俄国人当年足以与西方对抗简直是笑话。可是当时的人看到俄国的卫星首先上天的时候，看到苏联及其仆从国进行大规模军事演习的时候，他们并不会这么认为。北约对于苏联的重视不是假的，西欧许多国家所进行的预防核战争的演练也不是假的，人在历史进程当中的时候原本就很难去判断世界正通往何方，如果对于人类迄今为止的历史进程缺少整体的把握想要做出准确判断就更是痴人说梦。所以说不管是西欧各国的人民也好，还是以美国为首的西方阵营的各国政府也好，他们在试图对抗的是一个“观念”中的苏联，而那个真实的，自身难以为继的苏联恐怕即使美国等国家没有耗费这么多心力也不会晚死几年。

而观念影响人们最为长久和有名的一个例子莫过于骑兵，当骑兵作为一个独立兵种刚登上历史舞台没多久的时候，古希腊军事家色诺芬（Xenophon）就明确指出骑兵并不值得畏惧。士兵在面临骑兵冲锋的时候会担心被战马践踏，但是骑兵不是在操控一个没有感情的机器，他所骑的马本身也惧怕去冲撞步兵，对于马来说即使不是受到重伤而仅仅是腿受到了永久性伤害，这与给马判死刑也没多少区别了。因此当骑兵不顾一切地冲向敌人的时候，马本身就会出于本能进行一定的闪避。色诺芬极为精当地指出，非但步兵应该不怕骑兵，反倒是骑兵应该更畏惧步兵，因为步兵站立在坚实的大地上，而骑兵反倒需要害怕坠马（当然我们也要全面地指出，在色诺芬的时代，一些对于骑兵作战至关重要的马具的确还没有出现）。16至19世纪欧洲各国军事家以及各国的军事操典中都多次提及了这一点，可以说色诺芬在骑兵刚刚出现的时候就已经把这个兵种给看透了，要想应对骑兵冲锋，只需要一支训练有素，面对敌人的威吓阵型不动摇的步兵足矣，我国两宋之交立下赫赫战功的抗金武装就是如此。可就是这样一个刚刚出现就被研究透的兵种，人们却能发现在两千年间多少场战役中骑兵起到了使敌军军阵动摇的效果，很多时候甚至不是以弓马骑射这种对于骑兵来说最高效的作战方式取得的，仅仅是依靠威吓式的冲锋就足以让训练不足的敌人阵脚大乱。

这是一个非常有趣的事情，当色诺芬指挥麾下的希腊雇佣兵南征北战时，希腊还处于城邦林立的辉煌年代，由城邦公民组成的重步兵军队的确自然而然地就起到了克制骑兵的效果。但是在封建化的中前期或者没有经历封建化的地区以及像中国这样封建化中断的地区，想要获得一支军事素养强悍的军队都并不容易，战争常常在被强行征发的乌合之众之间展开，对于这些庞大但是质量低下的军队，封建军事贵族的骑兵自然可以热刀切黄油一样取得胜利，这种战例就更加加剧了人们对于骑兵的恐惧。事实上虽然不太了解欧洲老百姓对于骑兵这个已经退出历史舞台的兵种的看法，但我可以很笃定地说中国人眼中历史上的骑兵一定要远远强于欧洲人眼中，这是因为中国的官僚帝国以如此可笑的方式被于一定程度上封建化的蛮族打垮的例子实在太多了，我们国家很多人潜意识里精锐骑兵只要一冲锋胜局就已经确定，甚至无法理解为什么骑射才是骑兵最为高效的作战方式（理论上骑兵去冲击列阵步兵成本极高而且风险太大，但是因为中华帝国的军队总是大而无当，所以敌人如果采取这种反常识的行为往往会取得非常好的效果），我国的军事论坛上总是十分推崇重骑兵。这样一来，骑兵冲锋所给人们带来的生理恐惧就在战争事实的积累中扩大为了一种将骑兵神化的观念，而在中国这种观念会更为牢固。因此人们困于一些本能上的感知或者因为所认识到的事实具有局限性而产生错误的观念，并反过来被这种错误的观念束缚甚至进而做出错误的决定实在不是什么罕见的事情，时常反思自己的立场，认真考虑还有没有遗漏的信息实在是一件必要的工作。